

Response Letter with Annotations

González-Bailón, S., & Lazer, D. (2025). Scientific standards suffer from misrepresenting past work. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122(47), e2522011122. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2522011122>

Annotations

1. Purposes

- a. Motivation: respond to Krause et al. (2025) critic towards González-Bailón et al. (2023)' research based on 2020 Meta project
- b. Specific Rationale

Critic from Krause et al. (2025)	Response from González-Bailón & Lazer (2025)	Note
...granting industry partners control over the coding of variables... (p.5)	/	González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) do not direct respond to this, but claim that this may not lead to the concern of "Mata try to absolve their platforms of responsibility"
Meta invest to contradict existing scholarship on phenomena like filter bubbles, in order to absolve their platforms of responsibility for adverse effects on society or individuals (p.7)	they misunderstand the results: ideological segregation in news consumption on Facebook is three times as high as segregation on the web. How this finding 'absolves' platforms of responsibility?	It's true, but González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) do not mention that, their core conclusion is that despite the segregation, issue polarization, affective polarization, users' political knowledge, and other key variables do not change significantly
...quality standards related to replicability and reproducibility... (p.5)	we pre-register and disclose in other documents: Replication data and code for the studies published as part of this collaboration are archived at the University of Michigan's Social Media Archive (SOMAR) as part of the Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research (ICPSR) (https://socialmediaarchive.org) and made	It makes sense, but I believe that Krause et al. (2025) are not concerned with the issues in the data analysis process, but rather with the possibility that the labeled data obtained at

	available in the ICPSR virtual data enclave for university IRB-approved research on elections or to validate the findings of the studies	the beginning might have been filtered by Meta.
... creation of "gated" panels of users on various platforms...Users in these “research panels” would not be included in proprietary, commercial A/B testing and would, therefore, be unaffected by algorithms that could confound research (p.8)	their suggestion is not feasible: a combination of shared platform independent data collection and government-mandated data sharing (along the lines of the European Union’s Digital Services Act), holds the most promise to address data access asymmetries	Agree!

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Response Letter (~600 words)

It's my first time to read academic critic and response. Before discussing the specific content, I'm wondering whether this kind of pure comment or cursory reply can be regarded as publication. Do those journals deliberately leave pages for them, or assign places for them randomly? Should critic and response be published on the same journal? Is it common in certain disciplines or universal? Are there any motivations of publishing such critic other than friendly academic conversation?

Anyway, the above are just some random and less important thoughts. Coming back to this paper, González-Bailón & Lazer (2025), they replied back to three major critics from Krause et al. (2025). Personally speaking, although González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) have convincingly demonstrated the rationality of their research procedures, I feel that their responses still cannot fully address Krause et al. (2025)'s concerns. Krause et al. (2025) mainly raised questions about the potential manipulation of Meta and replicability, reproducibility of the research, as Meta undertook the process of conceptualization of core variables without intervention of academic researchers. González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) did find evidence of the negative impact of Facebook's algorithm – leading to greater ideological segregation. However, they also discovered that this segregation did not influence issue polarization, users' political knowledge, and other key variables significantly, which can, objectively, still act as a positive piece of evidence to Meta. It remains hard to tell whether Meta will use this finding to defense itself.

Second, González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) claimed that they have followed the procedure of preregistration, disclosed COI, and provided data for replication and validation. I agree with their arguments that researchers' prior connections with Meta might be helpful for facilitating this cooperation, but this procedural disclosure did not absolve the concern that the research might have been influenced by Meta's self-interests.

In addition, González-Bailón & Lazer (2025) did not deny that they relied on the labeled data from Meta, which I personally think should be the greatest concern. As long as the researchers are not involved in the conceptualization process, any attempts of disclosure can only be seem as increasing transparency from the researchers' end, rather than uncovering the black box of how Meta pre-processed the data, and how this may influence the replicability and reproducibility of the research.

P.S. Some responses to frequently asked questions: T. Stroud, J. A. Tucker, A. Franco, C. P. Kiewiet de Jonge, U.S. 2020 Facebook & Instagram Election Study (2023).
https://medium.com/@2020_election_research_project/us-2020-facebook-instagram-election-study-frequently-asked-questions-faq-266d30cbe95b.